



Ministry of Housing,
Communities &
Local Government

UK Shared Prosperity Fund: Intervention- level Evaluation

Support for People & Skills

FINAL REPORT

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Executive Summary

About this evaluation

This report presents findings from the intervention-level evaluation of selected UK Shared Prosperity Fund (UKSPF) **People & Skills projects**. The report was prepared by Frontier Economics and BMG Research for the Ministry of Housing, Communities & Local Government (MHCLG). The findings are intended to support policy makers and local authorities in decisions on future funding and programme design. Technical details are provided in the annex (see [‘UKSPF intervention-level evaluation final technical annex: support for people and skills’](#)).

Local areas used UKSPF funding to support economically inactive people (defined as working aged people who are not working, actively seeking employment or in education or training) to move closer to, and into, employment. **The nine projects in this evaluation provided £30 million of support to around 8,000 economically inactive participants across the UK.** Each locally designed and delivered project delivered a combination of support activities to between 110 and 2,250 people.

Support usually began with a one-to-one diagnostic consultation with an advisor or mentor, to identify participants’ needs and barriers. Projects then tailored support, including training, qualifications, coaching, mentoring and referrals to external services.

The evaluation pooled participant data into a single dataset after distinctions between projects and their objectives became less clear. Participants were analysed by barriers to employment, soft skills, education and personal characteristics, enabling clearer assessment of what worked for different groups.

The concept of “**distance travelled**” **towards employment was central** to the evaluation. This recognises that participants start from different positions and that progress towards work can take several forms including employment, qualifications, improved soft skills, reduced barriers and greater readiness for work.

A key focus was to understand the link between soft skills and movement towards employment. This evaluation used a novel approach to measure perceived improvements in soft skills, and their correlation with employment outcomes. It also examined what support was delivered, who it reached, what outcomes were achieved and to what extent the support plausibly contributed to those outcomes.

A contribution analysis evaluation approach was used, underpinned by a theory of change. Seven contribution claims were tested using monitoring data, qualitative evidence and survey responses from 799 participants who received support.

For each claim, the analysis considered changes in outcomes, participants’ own assessment of the influence of the support, evidence on how the support led to change, and other factors that could also explain the outcomes. As no counterfactual group was available, the approach assessed whether the support plausibly contributed to the outcomes rather than establishing causality.

Evidence strength for each contribution claim was assessed using a structured framework (see [‘UKSPF intervention-level evaluation final technical annex: support for people and skills’](#)). This considered the quality, volume and consistency of evidence, and the extent to which alternative explanations could be ruled out. Findings were classified high-, medium- or low-strength. **All findings included in this report are rated as either “high-strength” or “medium-strength”, meaning that it is at least reasonably clear that the support contributed to the outcomes.**

The evidence captures short-term outcomes only, usually **around a month** after UKSPF support ended for each participant. Longer-term outcomes may not yet have emerged. The findings are based on selected projects and should not be read as representative of the whole UKSPF People & Skills programme but provide an initial evidence base that can be tested and expanded over time.

Key findings

Cohort	Funded support contributed to...	Evidence strength
All participants	Moving closer to and into employment	High
	Improvements in wellbeing	Medium
Recently inactive participants	Overcoming personal barriers to employment	Medium
	Moving into active job search and securing employment	Medium
Long-term inactive participants	Overcoming personal barriers to employment	Medium
	Moving into active job search and securing employment	Medium
Hard-to-reach/ disengaged young people (not in education, employment or training)	Re-engagement with the education system	Medium

High-strength evidence shows that the support contributed to participants moving closer to, and into, employment.

Across all projects, personalised one-to-one support helped individuals move into employment or closer to work. Within around one month of support ending:

- 35% of participants had entered employment; and
- A further 53% had made progress towards employment, for example by gaining qualifications, receiving job offers or improving soft skills.

Together this means that **around 90% of participants reduced their distance from the labour market.** This is notable given that support targeted economically inactive people,

who are often further from work than participants in other employment support programmes.

Medium-strength evidence from qualitative sources shows that support contributed to improvements in wellbeing across all types of participants. For some participants, wellbeing improvement was an outcome in its own right. For others, it was also an enabler of progress towards employment or training. Quantitative evidence on wellbeing was not available for analysis because, when the survey was designed, wellbeing was not identified as a priority outcome and the limited survey space was instead used to measure soft skills, barriers, perceptions of support and employability outcomes.

Outcomes varied depending on participants' starting points, including their soft skills, time spent economically inactive and the nature of the barriers to employment they faced. Medium-strength evidence shows that support contributed to:

- **Recently inactive participants overcoming personal barriers to employment, moving into active job search and securing employment.** Reported barriers reduced by 38%, from 2.0 barriers before support to 1.3 after support on average. Half (50%) of recently inactive individuals moved into employment or active job search after support: 32% secured employment and 18% were actively seeking work or had a job offer.
- **Long-term inactive participants overcoming personal barriers to employment, moving into active job search and securing employment.** Reported barriers reduced from 2.2 barriers before support to 1.6 after support on average: a 27% reduction. Over half (57%) of long-term inactive individuals moved into employment or active job search after support. This included 31% who secured employment and 26% who were actively seeking work or had a job offer. This was similar to the recently inactive cohort, despite a higher level of starting barriers.
- **The re-engagement of disengaged young participants with the education system.** Around four-fifths (79%) of young people gained qualifications, while almost a quarter (24%) moved into employment.

Participants who addressed barriers and improved soft skills were more likely to progress towards employment.

How support contributed to change

Addressing barriers was important: across all participants, barriers reduced by 38% on average. Barriers were reduced through confidence-building, practical employability support, and signposting or advocacy with wider services.

Those who no longer reported barriers were more likely to enter employment than those whose barriers persisted. This link between reducing barriers and moving into employment was seen for those starting with high levels of barriers, not just those with low starting levels of barriers. Further, not all barriers needed to be removed to progress towards employment.

Improving soft skills was a key outcome, often facilitated through reducing barriers. Eighty-five per cent of recently inactive participants and 72% of longer-term inactive participants said the support had helped at least one soft skill.

Improving soft skills was a route to moving into employment. Participants who had improved their soft skills were more likely to move into employment: a one-point increase in soft skills was statistically significantly associated with a 6% higher likelihood of moving into employment. These skills increases mattered because they affected whether participants felt able to attend appointments, engage with training, contact employers, apply for jobs or follow through on referrals.

Delivery models based on trusted relationships between advisors and participants, combined with the flexibility to tailor support, were central to achieving these outcomes. Advisors were able to exercise judgement over the intensity, sequencing and type of support provided. Flexible budgets for advisors also helped address practical barriers, such as transport.

This flexibility enabled projects to reach participants in accessible ways, including through meetings in community settings rather than formal or centralised locations. Strong local partnerships with specialist providers also helped projects address a wide range of barriers in a coordinated way.

For many participants, particularly those with more complex needs, progress involved stabilising their circumstances before employment or training became realistic. This included addressing issues such as mental health, housing or financial challenges, alongside building skills and confidence.

Types of outcomes varied across different groups

The types of outcomes achieved varied across participant groups. Participants closer to the labour market, such as those with higher initial skill levels or shorter periods of economic inactivity, were more likely to move directly into jobs. Younger participants and those further from the labour market were more likely to progress by gaining qualifications, entering education, improving skills or increasing their readiness for work.

Support was effective for a wide range of individuals, including those with complex needs. Participants with lower starting skill levels or more complex barriers often experienced some of the largest improvements in soft skills and reductions in barriers, even where this did not translate into immediate employment within the evaluation period.

Wellbeing improvements were also widely reported in qualitative evidence. These were both a direct benefit of support and, for many participants, an important enabler of engagement with employability activities and future labour market progression.

This reinforces that progress is not expected to be uniform across participants and success should be judged both by employment outcomes and by credible progress towards work, particularly for participants starting further from the labour market.

Delivering value for money

Overall, the findings suggest that UKSPF-funded personalised support for economically inactive individuals can deliver positive outcomes and represent medium value for money, even within a relatively short timeframe. The evidence indicates that these outcomes were associated with relatively intensive, tailored forms of support.

Value for money was assessed using methods appropriate to each type of intervention over a five-year period by comparing project costs with observable benefits, consistent with relevant sector best practice, HM Treasury Green Book guidance and MHCLG value for money categories.^{1, 2} Given differences in methods and evidence, estimates should not be interpreted as directly comparable across interventions.

Employment and wellbeing benefits were monetised where possible and non-monetised benefits were also considered.

These findings should be interpreted cautiously. The analysis reflects short-term outcomes, excluding some wider benefits that could not be robustly monetised, and remains uncertain given the limited time since project completion. Further evidence would be needed to confirm whether these benefits are sustained over time.

Continuity of provision and the retention of experienced delivery staff were identified as important enablers of effective delivery. This suggests that stable funding and delivery arrangements can help maintain the advisor skills, local relationships and flexible support models associated with positive outcomes.

Implications for policy makers

Key findings include:

- **Protect trusted one-to-one advisor relationships.** The evidence consistently points to trusted relationships between participants and advisors as a central feature associated with positive outcomes. Delivery models that allowed advisors to build sustained relationships, exercise judgement, tailor support and signpost to other services appear to have underpinned effectiveness.
- **Maintain flexibility to address practical barriers.** Funding flexibility, including the ability of advisors to use budgets to address practical barriers such as transport, was regarded as key to success. Local partnerships with specialist providers were also important, enabling projects to address a wide range of barriers to employment in a coordinated way.
- **Support continuity in funding and delivery.** Longer funding periods would support continuity of provision and help retain experienced delivery staff. These staff skills, relationships and local knowledge were seen as important for effective delivery.
- **Recognise that personalised support can offer value for money.** Supporting economically inactive individuals with a range of needs can be done in a personalised way while offering value for money. Even under conservative assumptions and within a short observation window, the monetised benefits are expected to exceed costs, with additional benefits likely to emerge over time.
- **Value and monitor progress towards work, not only job entry.** Programmes of this type would not be expected to move all participants into employment within a short period. Future programmes should track intermediate outcomes such as

¹ [The Green Book - GOV.UK](#)

² [The MHCLG Appraisal Guide - GOV.UK](#)

reduced barriers, improved soft skills, qualifications and wellbeing, as these can be meaningful steps toward future employment.

Chapter 1: Introduction and methodology

1.1: Policy context and purpose of this report

The UK Shared Prosperity Fund (UKSPF) provided £3.5 billion of funding for local investment between 2022 and 2026, with the aim of supporting growth and promoting opportunities across all parts of the UK.

Local authorities had significant flexibility in how they spent UKSPF funding. This helped them to design projects to meet local needs. Projects varied in their scale, design and who they supported. In this report, a “project” refers to a locally designed and delivered programme of UKSPF-funded support for economically inactive local people.

This report presents findings from the intervention-level evaluation of selected UKSPF People & Skills projects that support economically inactive people to get closer to work. It focuses on:

- how projects were delivered (process evaluation);
- what outcomes were achieved and whether these plausibly reflect UKSPF contribution (impact evaluation); and
- whether benefits are likely to outweigh costs (value for money evaluation).

Findings are presented by study group and are not intended to be representative of the whole UKSPF programme.

1.2: The revised study group approach

It was not proportionate to evaluate all UKSPF interventions under the People & Skills theme across the UK. To manage diversity and generate transferable learning, the evaluation took a two-stage approach. First, it identified some groups of similar interventions, based on having shared objectives, target participants and delivery models, and allocated them to potential “**study groups**”. Three study groups were selected for evaluation based on feasibility, policy interest, coverage of different contexts and proportionate evaluation.

Projects within each study group were then selected according to criteria that ensured they were varied in size (UKSPF funding), scale (geographical coverage), UK nation, types of support provided, and their ability to address gaps in the evidence on the effectiveness of similar local interventions.

All study groups selected wanted to improve soft outcomes for inactive individuals but intended to target different groups within the inactive population. As the evaluation and understanding of the projects evolved, it became clear that the distinction between the study groups was increasingly blurred. Projects in fact targeted wide groups of people covering a spectrum of distances from employment.

Rather than sticking rigidly to the study group approach, data from across the study groups was pooled together to provide a single large dataset. This meant that the evaluation could explore what worked for different groups of participants. Grouping was done according to type of perceived personal barriers to employment, level of soft skills, existing education and personal characteristics. This was instead of grouping by study group, which would have been less precise.

This approach supports clear lessons on what works, for whom and under what conditions, and complements the [UKSPF place-based evaluation](#), which examines how combinations of interventions work within different types of places and alongside other local growth funding.

Further information on the selection of the study groups is available in the [Feasibility Report](#) and the approach to pooling project data in the [Early Update Report](#).

1.3: Overview of the interventions

The evaluation collected evidence from nine UKSPF-funded projects within the People & Skills theme, across three study groups.

The study groups were originally selected to cover three distinct types of projects, aimed at capturing various potential distances from employment:

- Those which targeted young people who were hard to reach and far from employment;
- Those which targeted a broad range of people with different distances to employment; and
- Those which targeted people who were perceived to be closer to employment when starting the support. These people were considered to be closer to employment than other inactive individuals but not necessarily “close” to employment.

Together, these projects supported around 8,000 economically inactive people, with targeted participants ranging from 110 to 2,250 per project. The survey sample (799) is smaller than the total number of participants supported but it includes participants from all study groups. It captures a broad range of participants across these projects.

These are all large projects: funding for delivering them from 2022 to 2025 ranged from £0.9 to £7.5 million per project. Most projects involved multiple delivery partners, with over 20 organisations involved in these nine projects. There is substantial variation in the size of the projects (by funding and participant numbers). Bias in the findings was minimised by the analysis focusing on individuals rather than projects and the triangulation across data sources to avoid over-reliance on a single source.

The projects all used multiple recruitment methods for participants, combining Jobcentre Plus referrals with referrals from health providers and local voluntary and community organisations and bespoke community outreach. Self-referral was also permitted for all of the projects. Participation was voluntary for all projects.

The projects were drawn from across the UK, reflecting a range of local contexts.

- England: Liverpool City Region and Durham;
- Wales: Cardiff and Blaenau Gwent;
- Scotland: Fife; and
- Northern Ireland: One project is Northern Ireland-wide, a second focuses on Belfast, and a third covers Newry, Mourne & Down and Armagh City, Banbridge & Craigavon Councils.

1.3.1: Reducing the distance to employment

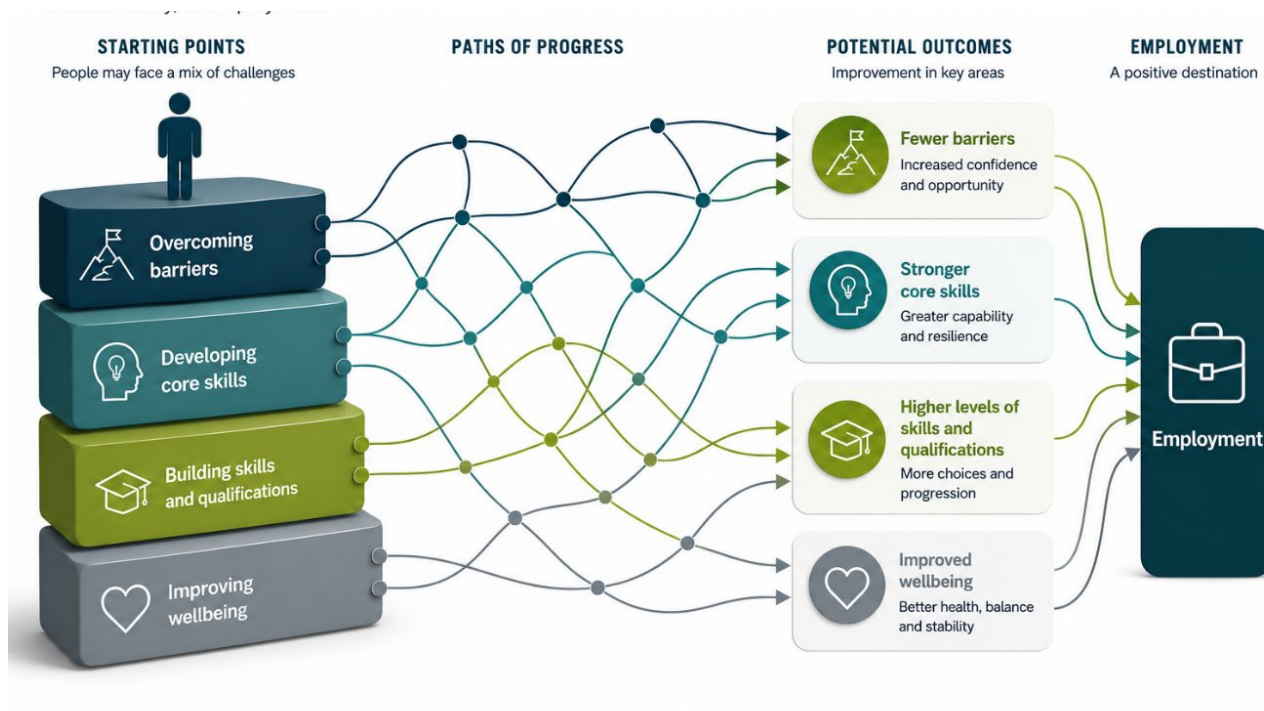
Filling the evidence gap on the links between improvements in some “soft” outcomes for inactive individuals and movements towards and into employment was a particular focus of the evaluation. This evaluation provides new and valuable evidence with a novel approach to directly measure perceived soft skill improvements and their correlation with employment outcomes.

The concept of “distance travelled” towards employment was key. It was used to measure improvements in “soft outcomes” that are consistent with a movement towards “hard outcomes” such as employment or education.³ This evaluation defines soft outcomes as improved soft skills (like confidence and job search skills) or the removal of perceived barriers to employment. This is grounded in existing evidence and developed with the theories of change for the projects (see [‘UKSPF intervention-level evaluation final technical annex: support for people and skills’](#)).

The starting distance to employment varies for every inactive individual due to the unique combination of barriers to employment they face and their initial soft skills, education and qualification levels. Projects did not anticipate that all individuals, regardless of starting position, would be able to move into employment from the intervention. This means that what is needed to move a participant closer to employment is a function of the starting place. Figure 1 shows this.

³ Barnes, S-A., Wright, S., 2019. [The feasibility of developing a methodology for measuring the distance travelled and soft outcomes for long-term unemployed people participating in Active Labour Market Programmes](#), Warwick Institute for Employment Research, European Commission.

Figure 1 The journey towards employment



Source: Frontier Economics and BMG

1.3.2: Support was tailored to the individual

All projects offered broadly similar approaches to identifying and providing the support that individual participants needed. They all included an initial assessment stage where the individual's current skills and barriers were identified, with a bespoke programme of support being designed for the individual following this assessment. Projects could offer tailored support and training from a long list of options, from formal training that resulted in qualifications to informal coaching and mentoring.

All projects included some form of one-to-one support and were able to adjust the frequency and nature of this support to respond to the individual's needs and specific circumstances. In most cases, the length of time support was provided for varied by participant, although the majority of support lasted between 3 and 12 months. All projects also signposted participants to other specialist support organisations where necessary, with delivery staff acting as connectors and advocates.

1.4: Evaluation approach

The evaluation questions focus on what works, for whom and under what conditions, including the conditions for delivering value for money. For detail on the approach, see ['UKSPF intervention-level evaluation final technical annex: support for people and skills'](#).

1.4.1: Evaluation framework and contribution analysis

The evaluation was designed around a theory-based framework, underpinned by theories of change for each study group (see [‘UKSPF intervention-level evaluation final technical annex: support for people and skills’](#)). These set out how UKSPF-funded support was intended to lead to economically inactive people moving closer to and into employment.

Given the localised project delivery and the infeasibility of sufficient quasi-experimental designs within this evaluation period, the evaluation used contribution analysis as its primary impact approach. Contribution analysis is recognised in HM Treasury’s Magenta Book as a robust method for assessing whether, how and why an intervention has plausibly contributed to the observed outcomes, particularly in complex settings where controlled comparisons are not feasible.⁴

The contribution analysis approach involved developing a set of contribution claims, which defined how support was expected to influence employment outcomes, and provided a structured basis for testing whether the expected pathways set out in the theory of change were supported in practice.

The evaluation tested these claims using a combination of quantitative evidence (including survey data on changes in outcomes and self-reported attribution) and qualitative evidence (from interviews and focus groups) to assess how and why outcomes occurred. Qualitative evidence was also used separately as part of the process evaluation to understand how support was delivered and experienced.

The analysis used econometric techniques to explore how outcomes varied across different participant groups. This allowed an understanding of the relative effectiveness of this type of support for delivering different outcomes for different groups.

For further information on the approach design, see the [Feasibility Report](#).

1.4.2: Contribution claims tested

Across the pooled dataset of participants, seven contribution claims were developed, reflecting the key pathways to impact set out in the theory of change (see [‘UKSPF intervention-level evaluation final technical annex: support for people and skills’](#)):

1. UKSPF support helped recently inactive people to overcome personal barriers to employment.
2. UKSPF support contributed to recently inactive people moving into active job search and securing employment.
3. UKSPF support helped long-term inactive people to overcome practical personal barriers to employment.
4. UKSPF support contributed to long-term inactive people moving into active job search and securing employment.

⁴ [HM Treasury Magenta Book 2026](#)

5. UKSPF support contributed to the re-engagement of disengaged young people with the education system.
6. UKSPF support contributed to participants moving closer to and into employment across all cohorts.
7. UKSPF support contributed to improvements in wellbeing across all participant groups.

Contribution claims 1-5 group participants by different distances from employment and the outcomes achieved. Distance from employment refers to how close a participant is to being ready and able to enter work, taking account of employment status, job search activity, qualifications, education, soft skills and reported barriers. Soft skills in this evaluation covered confidence, employability skills, job search skills and setting, and achieving goals.

1.4.3: Data sources

The evaluation drew on project monitoring data, surveys and qualitative evidence from interviews and focus groups:

- **Bespoke survey** was administered to participants as a baseline at the start of their support and as an opt-in survey within around a month of completing support. A response rate of 20% for the follow-on survey provided data on 799 participants across all projects with before-and-after data. The dataset combined information on the starting characteristics and barriers to employment facing individuals with information on soft (confidence, readiness for work, etc.) and hard outcomes (employment, qualifications, job offer, etc.) before and after the projects.
 - **Monitoring data** were provided by most projects and was incorporated into the dataset with the survey data. This included employment outcomes captured by the project, which were compared with employment outcomes reported by the participants in the surveys
- **Qualitative evidence** from semi-structured interviews with participants, delivery partners, frontline staff and local authorities provided additional insight into how support was delivered, experienced and perceived. Focus groups helped to contextualise the survey findings and understand how support contributed to outcomes in practice.
- **Contextual** information, such as local labour market statistics on travel to work times and unemployment rates, was used to interpret and frame the findings.

The data collection was designed to minimise burdens on participants, delivery staff and local authorities, recognising their limited time and capacity.

1.4.4: Impact evaluation quantitative approach

The survey data enabled before-and-after analysis by participant.

More robust econometric analysis explored how outcomes varied across different groups within the inactive population, including consideration of how outcomes varied by starting barriers, soft skills and personal characteristics. This allowed an understanding of the relative effectiveness of these projects for delivering different outcomes for different groups.

The findings are considered robust as a result of the large sample size and because the characteristics of those in the follow-up survey were similar to those who only provided baseline data (see [‘UKSPF intervention-level evaluation final technical annex: support for people and skills’](#)).

The findings are likely to provide transferable learning for similar programmes given that they cover both a range of geographical settings and contexts and individuals sitting across the broad spectrum of distance to employment.

1.4.5: Assessing the strength of evidence

The strength of evidence for each of the seven contribution claims was assessed using a bespoke framework (see [‘UKSPF intervention-level evaluation final technical annex: support for people and skills’](#)). Ratings reflect the quality, volume and consistency of evidence across sources, and the extent to which alternative explanations could account for the outcomes observed:

- High-strength evidence means that the theory of change was validated, at least three different sources of evidence or analysis produced similar findings, almost all evidence pointed to the same conclusion, and other drivers were judged to have had only a minimal influence on the outcome.
- Medium-strength evidence means that the theory of change was mostly validated, most evidence pointed to the same conclusion, and other drivers were likely to have influenced the outcome, but less so than the UKSPF support.
- Low-strength evidence means that there was either an absence of sufficient evidence to draw a conclusion or that the theory of change could not be validated, evidence pointed to differing conclusions and other factors could have explained the outcomes.

Each contribution claim was assessed as having high-, medium- or low-strength evidence, or as having insufficient evidence at this stage (see [‘UKSPF intervention-level evaluation final technical annex: support for people and skills’](#)).

1.4.6: Assessing value for money

Value for money (VfM) is defined by HM Treasury as a balanced judgement about the optimal use of public resources to achieve intended outcomes. In this context, VfM is assessed using a framework consistent with the HM Treasury Green Book guidance, combining monetised benefits with wider non-monetisable outcomes.⁵

The analysis monetised employment outcomes achieved within the timeframe of the evaluation, using wage benefits as the primary monetised benefit. It also considered the

⁵ [The Green Book - GOV.UK](#)

potential value of intermediate outcomes, such as participants gaining qualifications, entering education or training, receiving job offers or actively looking for work, where these outcomes may lead to employment in the future. Wellbeing benefits associated with employment were also monetised separately.

Estimates were based on impact evaluation findings, combined with conservative assumptions drawn from published literature and government guidance. Benefits were assessed over a five-year time horizon and discounted in line with Green Book guidance. Key assumptions, including the expected duration of employment benefits and the likelihood that intermediate outcomes lead to employment, were tested through sensitivity analysis. As no counterfactual was available, the analysis used attribution and deadweight assumptions to estimate the share of outcomes that could reasonably be linked to the support.

The assessment of VfM used in this evaluation considered what level of benefits would be needed to outweigh the costs. This is because only some benefits were monetisable and the duration of benefits was also uncertain.

VfM categories were defined based on monetised benefit-cost ratios (BCRs), in line with MHCLG guidance. A BCR of 1 to 1.5 represents acceptable value for money, rising to very high value for money at a BCR above 4.⁶ These categories reflect monetisable outcomes only and should be interpreted alongside wider benefits that cannot be monetised. For further details, see [‘UKSPF intervention-level evaluation final technical annex: support for people and skills’](#).

1.5: Limitations for interpreting results

There are key limitations to consider when interpreting the results:

- Outcomes were observed around one month after participants finished support. The evaluation did not include a comparison group, so findings should be interpreted as contribution evidence rather than proof that all outcomes were caused by UKSPF support alone. However, the findings are consistent across survey evidence, econometric analysis, qualitative fieldwork and case-study evidence.
- The one-month response period was chosen to maximise responses. This means that it is not possible to comment on either the longevity of observed outcomes or how longer-term outcomes might evolve within this evaluation.
- The econometrics looked at the effectiveness of the projects at offering bespoke targeted support to individuals overall. It was not possible to analyse whether certain targeted activities offered within the projects worked well – for example, analysing the relative effectiveness of a work placement versus support in CV preparation across or within groups. It was not possible to systematically gather this data from local authorities. Even if it had been, it might still not have been possible to draw conclusions about the relative effectiveness of different activities given the highly varied starting positions of individuals.

⁶ [The MHCLG Appraisal Guide - GOV.UK](#)

- For feasibility reasons, it was not possible to compare outcomes relative to a counterfactual of no intervention to prove a causal link. Any conclusions about the contribution of the programme to outcomes also draw on the wider qualitative evidence.

Chapter 2: Key findings

2.1: Summary of findings

Across the People & Skills projects in this evaluation, UKSPF-funded support made a meaningful contribution to moving economically inactive participants closer to work. The strongest evidence is that participants reported fewer barriers, improved confidence and work-related skills, and moved into employment, active job search, education or qualifications.

The pathway to change varied by starting point:

- Recently inactive participants were more likely to convert support into immediate labour market activity.
- Long-term inactive participants also moved into employment or active job search, but often while continuing to manage more persistent barriers.
- Young people (under 25 years) in youth-focused projects were more likely to progress through education, qualifications and re-engagement, reflecting the design of those projects and the starting point of the participants they supported.

Qualitative evidence reinforced the complexity of participants' starting points. As one delivery partner explained:

“You can’t put somebody in one box and say, this is their challenge, because they come with a plethora of challenges. And that takes quite a while sometimes to support somebody and provide a provision that is on one hand bespoke but can address groups of people.” (Delivery partner)

These differences by starting point are explored in contribution claims 1 through 5.

The barriers reported by participants included perceived, practical and labour market barriers. Changes in reported barriers may therefore reflect actual changes in circumstances, changes in participants' ability to manage those barriers, or changes in how participants understood their options. For example, support could not directly change the type or number of jobs available locally, but it could help participants identify suitable roles, understand transferable skills, broaden the range of jobs they considered or manage practical constraints. The support intentionally aimed to change perceptions about the types of jobs appropriate for participants to apply to, even though the support could not change the actual jobs available.

The evidence supports the effectiveness of the personalised support model overall. It does not allow the evaluation to isolate the impact of individual activities, such as CV support, interview preparation, training or work placements. The common support model combined assessment, trusted one-to-one support, tailored sequencing, practical help, local delivery and referrals to specialist services.

Trusted relationships were central to this model. One delivery partner explained:

“All of the staff ... would talk about ... the building of the trust, which is so important, building trust with all of their participants and building a relationship with the participants, which takes time ... but in each of those areas, I think that has been really key to the delivery of ... the project.” (Delivery Partner)

This matters for policy because it suggests that personalised employment support for economically inactive people should not be judged only by immediate employment outcomes. Employment is the clearest end outcome, but for participants further from work, reduced barriers, improved confidence, qualifications, education or active job search can be meaningful steps towards later employment.

2.2: Contribution claim findings

2.2.1: Contribution claim 1: UKSPF support helped recently inactive participants to overcome personal barriers to employment

This claim relates to participants who had been out of work or full-time education for less than a year. This group made up 46% of survey respondents. It included many young people, who, by definition, could not have been out of work or education for long periods of time (58% of this group).

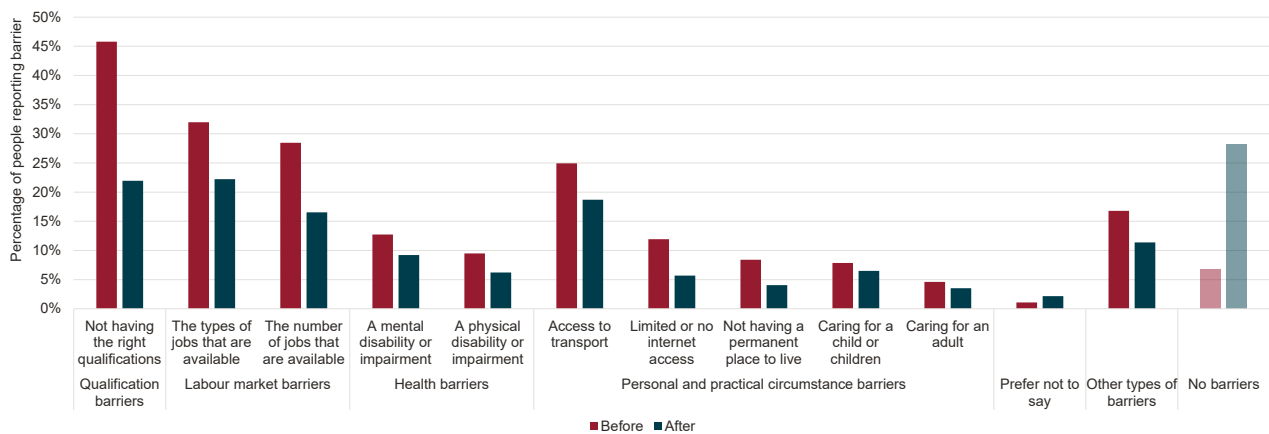
Survey evidence shows that recently inactive participants reported fewer barriers to employment after receiving support. On average, the number of reported barriers fell from 2.0 before support to 1.3 after support, a reduction of 38%. The share that reported 5 or more barriers also fell from 9% to 4%.

Among recently inactive participants who reported at least 1 barrier before support, 26% reported no barriers by the end of support. Among those that reported 5 or more barriers before support, 54% reported fewer than 5 after support.

Reported reductions were seen across all barrier types. The most common starting barriers for this group were not having the right qualifications, the types of jobs available, the number of jobs available and access to transport as shown in Figure 2. The number of participants that reported each of these barriers fell after support. The largest reductions were in the number that reported that they did not have the right qualifications, did not have a permanent place to live, or had limited or no internet access. Each fell by just over 50%.

Some barriers remained. After support, 22% still reported not having the right qualifications as a barrier, 22% reported the type of jobs available as a barrier and 19% reported access to transport as a barrier. This means that the evidence indicates that support helped many recently inactive participants to address or manage barriers but did not remove all constraints for all participants within the evaluation period.

Figure 2 Barriers before and after support for recently inactive participants



Source: Frontier Economics and BMG Research survey

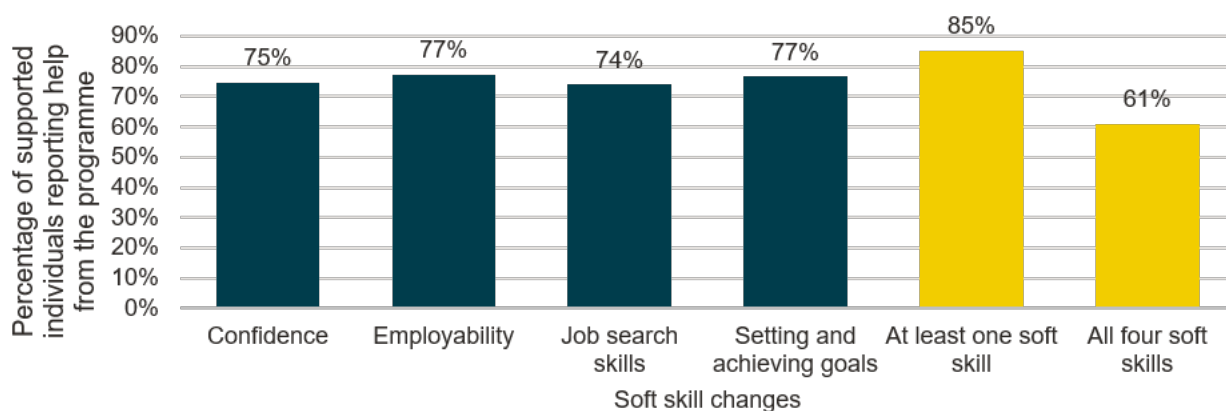
How support contributed to change

The evidence suggests that support contributed to reduced reported barriers through three linked routes:

1. confidence-building;
2. practical employability support; and
3. signposting or advocacy with wider services.

First, support helped participants build confidence and motivation. Survey evidence shows that 75% of recently inactive participants said the programme had helped improve their confidence and 77% said it had helped them set and achieve goals, as shown in Figure 3. These skills mattered because they affected whether participants felt able to attend appointments, engage with training, contact employers, apply for jobs or follow through on referrals.

Figure 3 Perception the support helped skills for recently inactive participants



Source: Frontier Economics and BMG Research survey

Second, support helped participants to develop employability and job search skills. Recently inactive participants had relatively low starting levels of job search skills, with an average self-rated score of 3.0 on a 6-point scale. After support, 74% reported that the programme had helped improve their job search skills and 77% reported that it had improved their employability skills.

Third, support helped participants to access wider services. Advisors and delivery staff signposted participants to specialist provision, helped them understand available support and, in some cases, advocated on their behalf. This was particularly important where barriers were linked to housing, health, caring responsibilities or digital exclusion. External services therefore acted both as an additional influence on outcomes and as part of the route through which UKSPF support contributed to change.

Qualitative evidence suggests this was more than simple signposting. As one delivery partner and local authority explained:

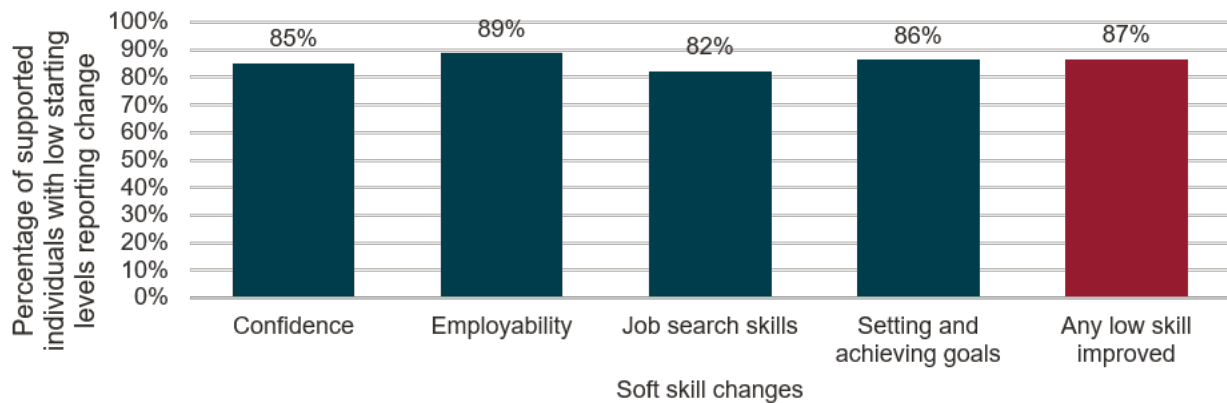
“We will seek the supplier that’s the closest to that individual that’s accessible to them ... it’s all about finding the provision that the individual needs that’s on their doorstep that they’re happy to engage with and then support them through that process ... It’s not just about making a referral to Citizens Advice [for example] for someone, and then a week later go ‘how did you get on’ and finding out that they didn’t turn up ... we hold their hand, we open the door, we show them through, we sit them down.” (Delivery partner)

“We were able to pay them [Citizens Advice] to give us some specified dedicated staff time rather than saying to people ‘You really should get to Citizen’s Advice, it’s down the road and you’ll probably wait three weeks’. That fast tracking was really important.” (Local authority)

The programmes appear to have helped participants through targeted support that addressed their needs in a range of ways depending on the barriers they faced. The

pattern of improvement from low starting scores, together with qualitative evidence from advisors and participants, suggests that support was indeed tailored to individual needs rather than delivered as a standardised package. Among participants who scored themselves 1 or 2 out of 6 in a soft skill area before support, more than 80% moved to a score of at least 3 after support, as shown in Figure 4.

Figure 4 Recently inactive participants with low starting levels of skills at the start reporting the support helped with soft skills



Source: Frontier Economics and BMG Research survey

The type and intensity of support varied between participants. For some, the emphasis was on building confidence and motivation. For others, it focused more on employability skills, job search activity, qualifications, work experience, signposting or advocacy with wider services.

These different forms of support were relevant to participants depending on their starting points and the barriers they faced. For example, improvements in confidence could make it easier for some participants to engage with training or job search activity, while practical support could help others see employment as more achievable. This tailored approach helps to explain why many participants reported fewer barriers to employment by the end of support.

The following two case studies provide illustrative examples, drawn from the experience of real participants, of what tailoring of the project meant in practice and how it helped beneficiaries get closer to employment. In both examples, the frequency and intensity of the support, including the one-to-one mentoring was matched to the beneficiary's needs, as is typical for the projects.

Case studies: Building confidence and readiness for employment through tailored mentoring, work experience and re-engaging with education

Case study 1 Profile: • Aged under 25 • Recent Level 2 course completion • Out of work for less than a year Barriers: • Neurodiversity • Anxiety • Lack of confidence • Unsure of pathways to work Support provided: • One-to-one mentoring • Developed an up-to-date CV • Set up job search accounts • Identified transferable skills gained through volunteering and training • Confidence-building sessions • Interview preparation • Completing further adult learning qualifications • A structured placement with a retailer to gain work experience Outcomes attributed to the support: • Work experience and ongoing volunteering • Improved routine and workplace skills • Active job search • Significant improvements in confidence, independence and readiness for employment	Case study 2 Profile: • Aged under 25 • Out of work for less than a year • No previous work experience Barriers: • Bad experience with formal education • Lack of confidence • Lack of qualifications Support provided: • One-to-one mentoring • Identification of skills and interests • Confidence-building sessions • Identification of a Level 2 course at a local college • Guidance with college application process • Practical travel training to reduce anxiety about attending the course independently Outcomes attributed to the support: • Completed Level 2 qualification • Improvements in confidence and independence • Positive feedback from qualification providers • Application for further courses at the local college with a plan to enter employment after completion
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Other factors influencing outcomes

Other factors may also have reduced reported barriers. Participants' personal circumstances may have changed, and some may have received informal or formal support outside the programme. The evaluation cannot fully rule out these explanations.

However, the evidence suggests that UKSPF support made a distinct contribution. Delivery partners consistently reported that participants faced complex and connected barriers, and that signposting alone would not have been sufficient for many of them. Local

authorities and delivery partners also reported limited availability of comparable support in many areas. Participants consistently reported that the programme had helped them make progress.

Taken together, the evidence does not show that UKSPF support was the only factor that influenced outcomes. It does suggest that other factors are unlikely to explain the full scale and pattern of barrier reduction observed.

Overall assessment of contribution

Medium-strength evidence suggests that personalised support contributed to reductions in reported barriers. This combines quantitative before-and-after survey data, self-reported impacts and qualitative evidence from local authorities, delivery partners and participants for how the personalised support enabled this.

2.2.2: Contribution claim 2: UKSPF support contributed to recently inactive participants moving into active job search and securing employment

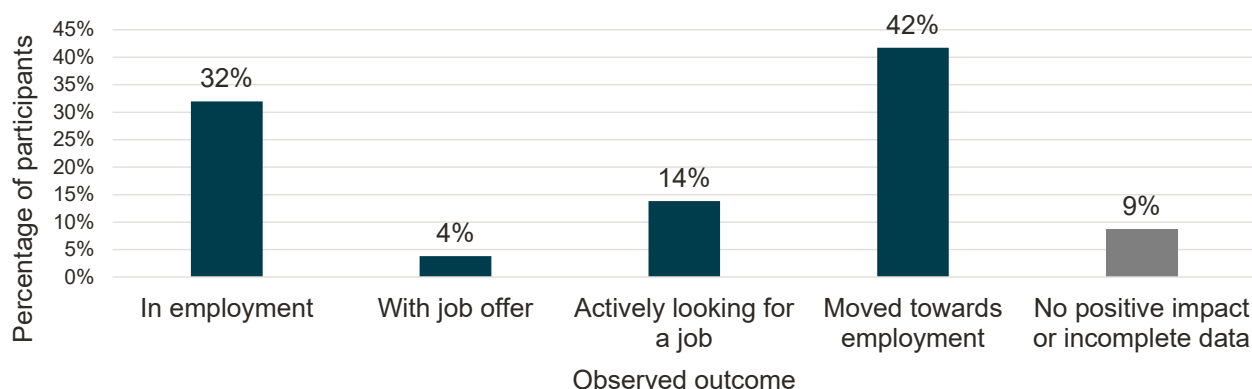
The previous claim showed that recently inactive participants reported fewer barriers after support. This claim considers whether that progress translated into movement towards work through active job search, job offers or employment.

Survey evidence shows that 50% of recently inactive participants moved into employment or active job search after support: 32% secured employment and 18% were actively seeking work or had a job offer.

For an economically inactive cohort, active job search is a meaningful outcome. It represents a move towards the labour market and, for some participants, a change in labour market status. This outcome should therefore be interpreted as more than a measure of intention: it shows that some participants moved from inactivity into practical job search activity.

This finding strengthens the contribution story from contribution claim 1. For many recently inactive participants, reduced reported barriers and improved soft skills were followed by active steps towards work.

Figure 5 Moves closer to and into employment for recently inactive participants



Source: Frontier Economics and BMG Research survey

How support contributed to change

Support appears to have contributed in three ways:

1. converting confidence and motivation into action;
2. providing practical employability and job search support; and
3. helping participants manage remaining barriers while moving towards work.

Survey evidence shows that, among recently inactive participants who moved into employment or active job search, 85% reported that the programme had helped with at least one soft skill. These skills helped participants look for work, apply for jobs, present themselves to employers and maintain momentum through recruitment:

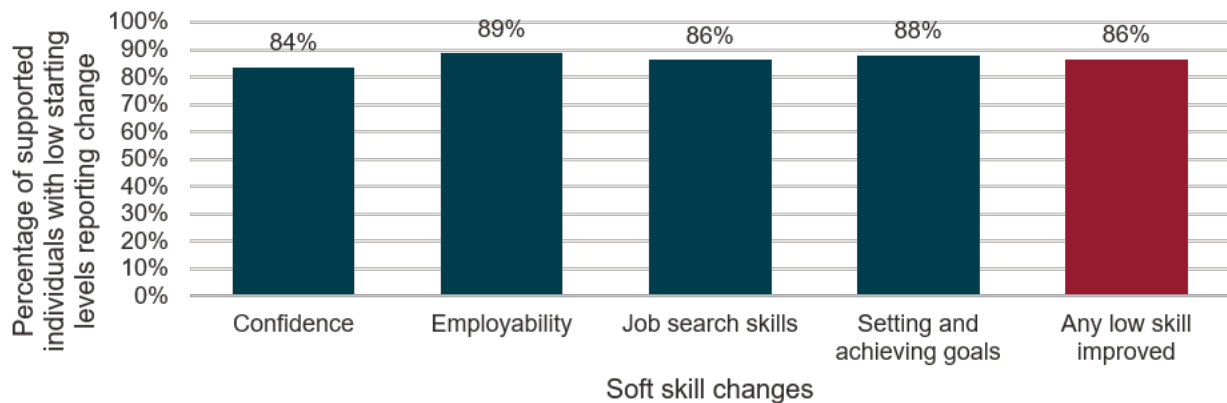
- 77% reported that it helped with confidence.
- 73% reported that it helped with setting and achieving goals.
- 85% of those that reported low scores for these skills at the outset reported that support had helped improve their job search skills and employability.

Support also helped participants develop practical skills directly linked to finding work. Among recently inactive participants who moved into active job search or employment, around 75% reported that support had helped improve their employability skills and job search skills. This included support with CVs, applications, interview preparation, vacancy searches and identifying suitable roles.

Participants who moved into employment or active job search reported improvements in the skills most closely linked to labour market action, particularly confidence, goal setting, employability and job search skills. Among those with low starting scores, close to 90% improved in each soft skill area as shown in Figure 6, although this finding is based on a smaller sample and should be interpreted cautiously.

This suggests that as well as being associated with general improvements in readiness for work, support was associated with improvements in the specific capabilities needed to move from inactivity into job search or employment.

Figure 6 **Reported improvement for recently inactive participants with low starting levels of skills at the start**



Source: Frontier Economics and BMG Research survey

The pattern for barriers and reductions in barriers also supports this interpretation.

At the start of the programme, recently inactive participants who moved into employment or active job search reported an average of 2.2 barriers to employment. This was higher than the average among recently inactive participants who did not see these outcomes, who reported 1.7 barriers at the start. This suggests that the labour market activity observed was not simply concentrated among those with the fewest starting barriers.

By the end of support, those who had moved into employment or active job search reported an average of 1.3 barriers. One-third of this group reported no remaining barriers to employment. Their most prevalent starting barriers were not having the right qualifications, the number of jobs available and the type of jobs available. This is consistent with support helping participants to reduce or manage the barriers most directly linked to labour market action.

Support was particularly important where participants had skills or experience but lacked confidence, direction or familiarity with current recruitment processes. Case-study evidence shows how support helped some recently inactive participants identify realistic employment routes, prepare for applications and interviews, and access roles aligned with their skills or interests.

Participant evidence also linked confidence to employment progress:

“It has given me confidence ... helped me to get a stable job ... the skills or the confidence that I've acquired here will help me a lot.” (Participant)

The pattern of outcomes also suggests that moving into work did not always require all barriers to be removed. Participants who moved into labour market activity reported

fewer barriers after support, but some still reported barriers at the end of the programme. This indicates that support sometimes helped participants manage remaining constraints, for example by identifying roles that were compatible with caring responsibilities, transport options, health needs or preferred hours.

The following two case studies provide illustrative examples, drawn from the experience of real participants, of progress that beneficiaries made towards moving to employment once some of their barriers had been addressed.

Case studies: Reduction of barriers enabled beneficiaries to move towards active job search and employment

Case study 3 Profile: • Middle aged • Extensive employment history • Recent redundancy Barriers: • Lack of confidence • Unfamiliarity with modern recruitment practices • Anxiety about interviews Support provided: • One-to-one mentoring • Support to create CV • Structured job search support • Careers advice • Support to register with online vacancy platforms • Interview preparation • Training to improve digital job search skills • Funding for interview clothing Outcomes attributed to the support: • Multiple interviews attended • Boosted confidence through positive interview feedback • Continued active job search, resulting in securing a role	Case study 4 Profile: • Aged under 25 • Out of work for 6 months • Care/support worker experience Barriers: • Lack of motivation • Unsure of how to find work • Unsure of how skills transferred to other sectors Support provided: • One-to-one mentoring • Sessions local to beneficiary • Support to update CV • Structured job search support • Identification of transferable skills • Support to complete applications • Bus pass to travel to interviews and job • Interview preparation Outcomes attributed to the support: • Application and interview for apprenticeship • Secured apprenticeship • Secured seasonal work • Further shift secured following seasonal work
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Other factors influencing outcomes

It was more plausible for recently inactive participants than for those inactive for longer to have moved into work without this UKSPF-funded support. Some participants

in this group may have moved into work or job search without UKSPF support, particularly those with more recent work or education experience and higher starting levels of soft skills.

However, this does not fully explain the outcomes observed. Recently inactive participants still reported material barriers at the start of support, and those barriers reduced after support. Participants who moved into employment or job search also reported that the programme had helped improve the confidence, goal setting, employability and job search skills needed to take practical steps towards work. Improvements in soft skills are closely associated with moving into employment (see contribution claim 6 for econometric analysis).

Local labour market conditions may also have influenced employment outcomes. Available contextual evidence does not suggest that unusually favourable local labour markets explain the outcomes observed (see [‘UKSPF intervention-level evaluation final technical annex: support for people and skills’](#)).

Overall assessment of contribution

The evidence is strongest when contribution claims 1 and 2 are read together.

Medium-strength evidence suggests that personalised support contributed to reduced reported barriers, improved relevant skills and helped many recently inactive participants convert readiness into active job search or employment. This combines quantitative before-and-after survey data, self-reported impacts and qualitative evidence from local authorities, delivery partners and participants for how the personalised support enabled this.

2.2.3: Contribution claim 3: UKSPF support helped long-term inactive participants to overcome personal barriers to employment

This claim relates to participants who had been out of work or education for more than a year. This group made up 36% of participants. Many were aged 24 or below, although young people made up a smaller share of this group than of the recently inactive group.

Survey evidence shows that long-term inactive participants started further from employment than recently inactive participants on several measures. They reported an average of 2.2 barriers before support, compared with 2.0 among recently inactive participants. Twelve per cent reported 5 or more barriers before support.

- After support, the average number of reported barriers fell from 2.2 to 1.6, a reduction of 27%.
- The share who reported 5 or more barriers fell from 12% to 7%.
- For those who reported at least 1 barrier before support, 13% reported no barriers after support.
- For those who reported 5 or more barriers before support, 39% reported fewer than 5 after support.

These reductions were smaller than for recently inactive participants but still indicate progress for a group that started further from work.

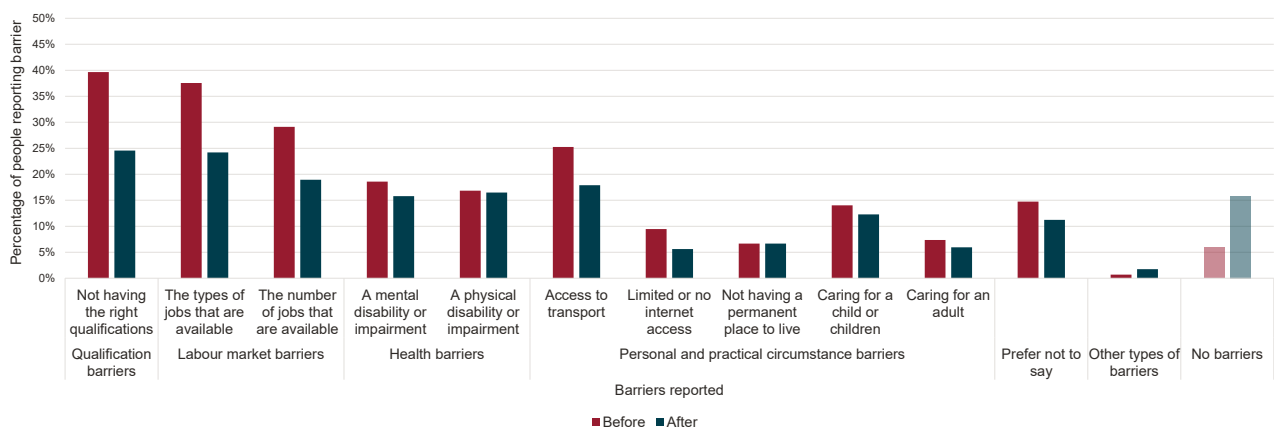
Reported reductions were seen across most barrier types. The most common starting barriers were not having the right qualifications, the type of jobs available, the number of jobs available and access to transport, as shown in Figure 7. The largest reductions in barriers were limited or no internet access, not having the right qualifications, and the number and type of jobs available. These fell by close to 40%. Delivery partners felt that many participants did not initially understand well what their barriers were or struggled to articulate them. Barriers selected in the baseline before the support may not be a full reflection of the barriers.

Participant qualitative evidence also supported a reduction in some barriers:

“I hadn’t worked in ten years. I had basically no qualifications. This [the employment support programme] is how I ended up doing courses.” (Participant)

Some barriers were more difficult to change for this group. There was no change in the number that reported not having a permanent place to live as a barrier, and only a very small change in those that reported a physical disability as a barrier. This suggests that the programme could help many long-term inactive participants reduce employment-related and practical barriers, but some structural, health and housing-related barriers remained difficult to resolve within the evaluation period.

Figure 7 Barriers before and after support for long-term inactive participants



Source: Frontier Economics and BMG Research survey

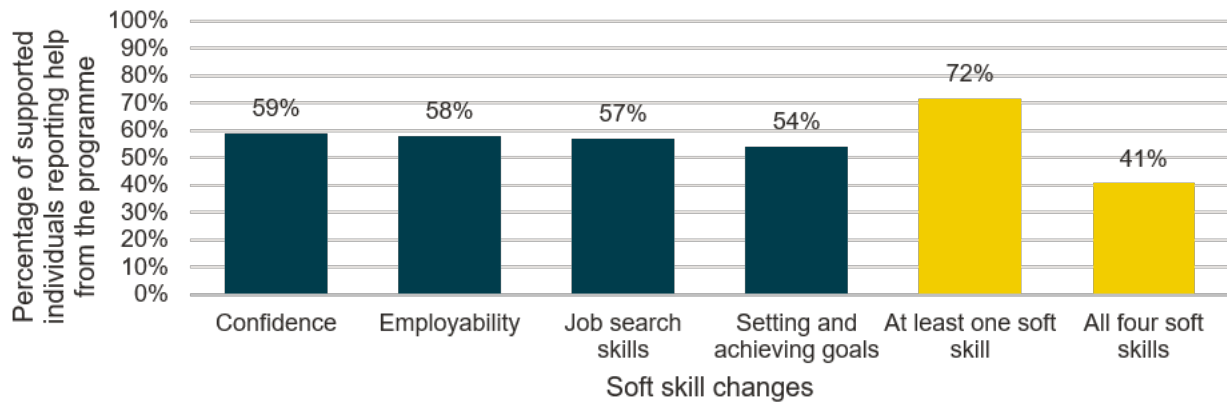
How support contributed to change

Support contributed through similar routes to those observed for recently inactive participants, but the pathway was often more intensive and uneven. The evidence suggests that support helped some long-term inactive participants substantially, while others continued to face significant barriers.

Survey evidence shows that 59% of long-term inactive participants reported that the programme had helped to improve their confidence and 54% reported that it had helped them to set and achieve goals, as shown in Figure 8. Although these proportions are lower

than for recently inactive participants, those who reported improvement were more likely to say that support had helped a lot.

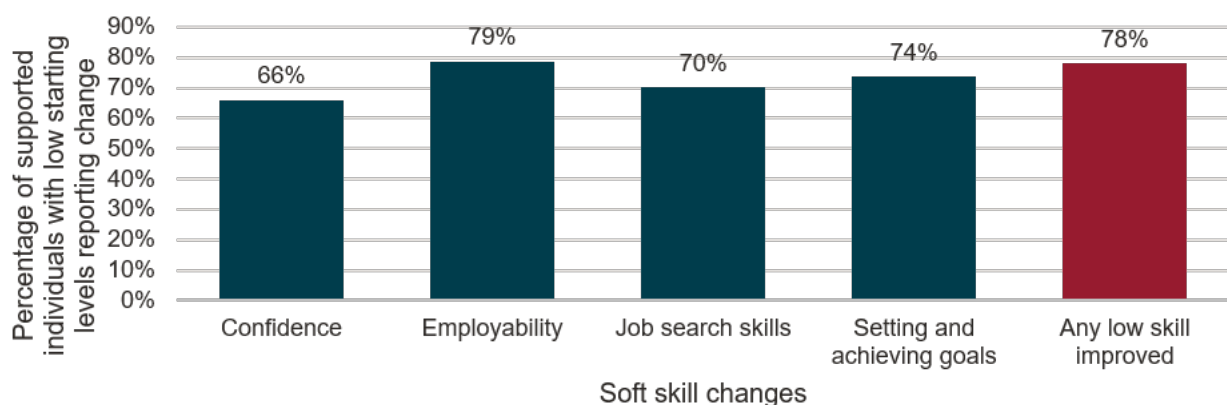
Figure 8 Perception the support helped skills for long-term inactive participants



Source: Frontier Economics and BMG Research survey

Support also helped with employability and job search skills. After support, 57% reported that the programme had helped improve job search skills and 58% reported that it had improved employability skills. More than 66% of long-term inactive participants who started with low scores in each soft skill area moved to a score of at least 3 after support, as shown in Figure 9.

Figure 9 Long-term inactive participants with low starting levels of skills at the start reporting the support helped with soft skills



Source: Frontier Economics and BMG Research survey

Case-study evidence shows how support helped people with long periods outside work. In some cases, support combined confidence-building, job search help, reassurance about

existing qualifications, digital access and interview preparation. In others, support first focused on rebuilding routine, confidence and stability before employment-related activity became realistic.

During a qualitative interview, one participant explained their early steps of support:

“I’ve been unemployed for about seven years. I kind of had a bit of a breakdown. Mental health issues, stuff like that. My Dad passed away and I didn’t deal with it very well. I kind of went into a bubble for seven years. Since I started [the programme] I have achieved a lot. They’ve put me through a lot of stuff, like a counsellor, and the grief course, paying for me to do my hygiene course.”
(Participant)

For long-term inactive participants, the programme often had to stabilise confidence and personal circumstances before employment-related support could be effective.

This is important for interpreting outcomes: smaller reductions in some barriers do not mean that support was ineffective. They reflect the more complex starting points of this group and the persistence of some structural or health-related barriers.

Qualitative evidence supports this interpretation. One local authority explained:

“When you’re working with somebody who’s economically inactive, their biggest issue is not getting a job ... it’s their mental health or ... about to be homeless ... staff need to know where to signpost.” (Local authority)

The following two case studies provide illustrative examples, drawn from the experience of real participants, of support being provided to beneficiaries who are long-term unemployed to help them overcome barriers to employment.

Case studies: Reduction of barriers enabled beneficiaries to move towards active job search and employment

Case study 5 Profile: • Aged over 60 • Out of work for 10 years • Recent volunteering activity Barriers: • Lack of confidence • Previous mental health issues • Digital exclusion • Lack of evidence of qualifications Support provided: • One-to-one coaching • Identification and mapping of skills • Job search support • Reassurance about qualifications • Access to a laptop • Support to complete online applications • Tailored interview preparation Outcomes attributed to the support: • Full-time employment • Increase in confidence • A role closely aligned with interests • Improved digital access	Case study 6 Profile: • Middle aged • Previous caring responsibilities • Loss of Carers Allowance Barriers: • No qualifications • No work experience • Debt Support provided: • One-to-one mentoring • Access to formal training courses • Benefits calculations to reassure work was affordable • Debt support, including arrangement of repayment plan • Support to apply for disability benefits (upon return) Outcomes attributed to the support: • Initial part-time employment • Increased confidence • Affordable debt repayment plan • Disability benefits (upon change of circumstances)
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Other factors influencing outcomes

Wider personal circumstances and other services may have contributed to reduced reported barriers. However, alternative explanations are less plausible for long-term inactive participants than for recently inactive participants because this group had been out of work or education for longer and generally faced more complex barriers.

Delivery partners consistently reported that confidence-building, practical support and advocacy were important for participants who had been detached from the labour market for longer periods. Local authorities and delivery partners also reported limited availability of comparable support in many areas.

Overall assessment of contribution

Medium-strength evidence suggests that personalised support contributed to reductions in reported barriers, although smaller than for recently inactive participants. This combines quantitative before-and-after survey data, self-reported impacts and qualitative evidence

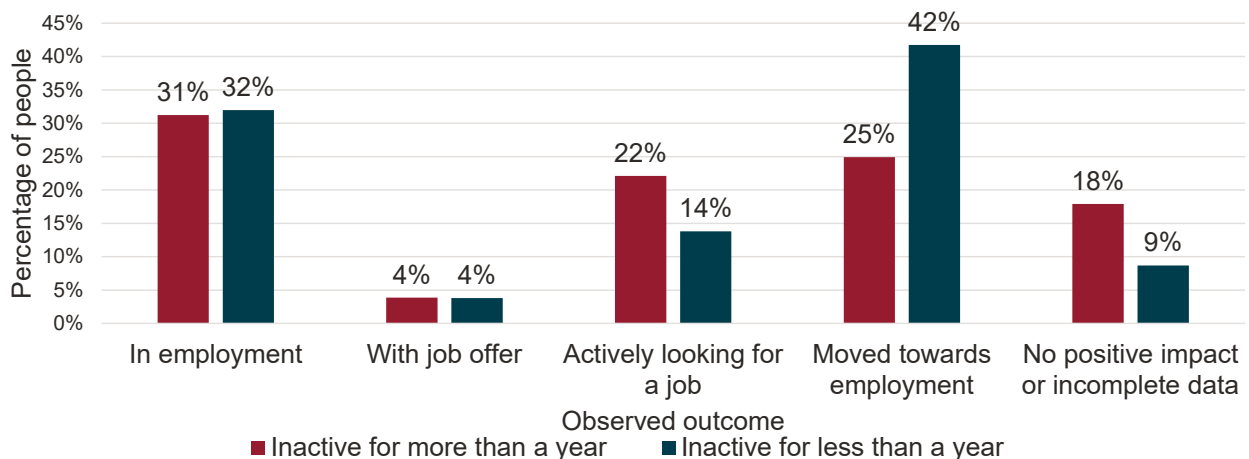
from local authorities, delivery partners and participants for how the personalised support enabled this.

2.2.4: Contribution claim 4: UKSPF support contributed to long-term inactive participants moving into active job search and securing employment

This claim considers whether the barrier and skill changes observed among long-term inactive participants translated into job search, job offers or employment.

Survey evidence shows that 57% of long-term inactive participants moved into employment or active job search after support. This included 31% who secured employment and 26% who were actively seeking work or had a job offer, as shown in Figure 10.

Figure 10 Moves closer to and into employment for recently inactive and long-term inactive participants



Source: Frontier Economics and BMG Research survey

This is a notable finding. Although long-term inactive participants reported higher starting barriers and smaller average reductions in barriers, their rate of movement into employment or active job search was comparable to the recently inactive group.

How support contributed to change

Support contributed by improving confidence, developing practical work-search skills and helping participants manage remaining barriers.

Among long-term inactive participants who moved into employment or active job search:

- 86% reported that the programme had helped with at least one soft skill;
- 70% reported that it had helped with confidence;
- 65% reported that it had helped with setting and achieving goals;

- 67% reported that it had helped with employability skills; and
- 67% reported that it had helped with job search skills.

For participants who started with low soft skill scores, more than 75% improved in each skill area. This suggests that support helped participants address deficits that could otherwise have prevented them from taking practical steps towards work.

Case-study evidence shows how this pathway worked for participants with very limited or no recent labour market experience. In some cases, support helped participants to recognise transferable skills gained through caring, volunteering or life experience, identify suitable roles and take a first step into paid work.

The key contribution point is that support did not always need to remove every barrier before progress was possible. For some long-term inactive participants, support helped them to recognise their capabilities, identify suitable work and take practical steps towards employment while continuing to manage wider personal circumstances.

This was reflected in qualitative evidence from delivery staff, who described the importance of building the confidence and coping skills needed before some participants could move towards work:

“You're setting them up [to] fail ... You need those soft skills ... and those coping skills built up.” (Frontline Staff)

The following two case studies provide illustrative examples, drawn from the experience of real participants, of beneficiaries being supported to move towards employment after long-term unemployment.

Case studies: Long-term unemployed beneficiaries undertaking active job search and securing employment

Case study 7 Profile: • Middle aged • No previous work experience • Early school leaver to raise family Barriers: • Victim of domestic abuse • Perception of low skills • Low confidence • Limited qualifications Support provided: • One-to-one mentoring • Strength and skills identification • Trauma-informed support environment • Slow pace to match needs • Specific domestic abuse support • Formalised training programmes • Identification of jobs that would work around caring responsibilities Outcomes attributed to the support: • Part-time employment • Increase in confidence • Increased independence	Case study 8 Profile: • Aged under 25 • Out of work for over a year • Previous short-term employment Barriers: • Living with parents • Jobless household • Lack of public transport • Lack of confidence and self-esteem Support provided: • Arranged volunteering • Identification of sectors of interest • Support to create tailored CVs • Interview skills course • Security qualification • Assistance with accommodation, including furniture • Outreach to organise interview Outcomes attributed to the support: • Employment with the delivery partner • Increased confidence • Accommodation with transport options
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Other factors influencing outcomes

Some outcomes may have been influenced by local labour market conditions, personal circumstances or other services. However, the explanation that participants would have moved into work without support is less convincing for this group than for recently inactive participants. Long-term inactive participants had lower baseline skills, longer periods outside work or education, and significant barriers to overcome.

The qualitative evidence also indicates that comparable provision was limited in many areas. This supports the view that UKSPF support made a distinct contribution, even where other services or personal circumstances also played a role.

Overall assessment of contribution

The evidence is strongest when contribution claims 3 and 4 are read together.

Medium-strength evidence suggests that personalised support contributed to reduced reported barriers, improved relevant skills and helped many long-term inactive participants convert readiness into active job search or employment. This combines quantitative before-and-after survey data, self-reported impacts and qualitative evidence from local authorities, delivery partners and participants for how the personalised support enabled this. The rating remains medium because the evaluation cannot isolate the specific effect of UKSPF support from all other influences.

2.2.5: Contribution claim 5: UKSPF support contributed to the re-engagement of disengaged young participants with the education system

Young people were supported through both youth-focused projects and broader People & Skills projects. The youth-focused projects intentionally targeted hard-to-reach young people, many of whom had limited engagement with education and were further from employment than young people in broader provision.

Lower short-term employment rates among young people in youth-focused projects should not be interpreted as weaker performance. These projects intentionally targeted young people further from work and placed greater emphasis on re-engagement, qualifications and education pathways.

Survey evidence shows that young people in youth-focused projects were less likely to enter employment within the evaluation period than young people in broader projects. Twenty-four per cent of young people in youth-focused projects entered employment, compared with 44% of young people in broader projects. However, young people in youth-focused projects were more likely to gain qualifications or move into education and training.

Nearly 80% (79%) of young people in youth-focused projects gained a qualification, compared with 27% of young people in broader projects. The difference in employment outcomes does not appear to be explained only by starting education levels. Young people with Level 2 or higher starting qualifications in youth-focused projects were still less likely to enter employment than those with equivalent starting education in broader projects.

This suggests that youth-focused projects were more oriented towards education and qualification outcomes in the short term. This is consistent with their purpose: to rebuild routine, confidence, skills and engagement with learning for young people who had become detached from education or work.

The relationship between qualifications and employment/actively looking for employment

Gaining a qualification is not a good predictor of moving into employment in this evaluation. Participants who gained a qualification were, in fact, less likely to be in employment than those who did not gain a qualification as part of the support. This relationship is stronger for participants who started with lower levels of soft skills and gained a qualification. That means that, when comparing two participants with lower levels of soft skills at the beginning of the project, the one who gained a qualification during the project was less likely to also be in employment compared to one who did not gain a qualification.

A potential explanation is that these participants, having spent the duration of the project working towards that qualification, did not find a job within the survey timings, and that gaining qualifications may have been more important for participants starting with lower levels of soft skills. Another possible reason is that a large proportion of participants who gained a qualification were in the study group for hard-to-reach young people, which tended more to have education outcomes.

Similarly, having gained a qualification did not affect the likelihood of actively looking for a job. The same explanations as above are relevant for this relationship.

How support contributed to change

The key route through which support contributed was the youth worker approach: flexible, relationship-based support that moved at the young person's pace and addressed wider personal barriers before focusing narrowly on employment.

One delivery partner described the early stages of their programme:

"Phase one of the programme is all about personal development and wellbeing. We don't mention qualifications, we don't mention jobs, we don't mention careers. That phase is on reducing the barriers of young people to engage in or build more trust ... Phase one is run by our youth mentors who all come from a youth work background. They do a lot of team building, confidence, self-esteem. If they need referrals for additional support ... anything around alcohol, drugs, childcare ... relationship advisors ... money, finance people, welfare rights people ... They just do a lot of things that set them up and deal with the initial issues that have caused them to be economically inactive." (Delivery partner)

Youth-focused projects appear to have been particularly effective at improving soft skills for young people with low starting levels. This matters because, for disengaged young people, confidence, motivation, routine and goal setting are often necessary foundations for education, training or employment outcomes.

Frontline staff described this as an intentional focus:

"For me it's education and skills outcomes. Skills development is the most important. And we've blasted that out of the sky." (Frontline staff)

Case-study evidence illustrates how this worked. For some young people with repeated disengagement from sixth form or college, caring responsibilities or mental health challenges, support focused first on trust, interests and strengths. This then enabled young people to explore education pathways, volunteering, qualifications or longer-term employment ambitions.

Re-engagement with education should therefore be treated as a meaningful labour market outcome for young people who are not ready to move directly into work. It can also provide a route to better-quality and more sustainable employment later.

The following two case studies provide illustrative examples, drawn from the experience of real participants, of young people re-engaging with the education system following support.

Case studies: Young beneficiaries being supported to re-engage with the education system

Case study 9 Profile: • Aged under 25 • Repeated disengagement from sixth form and college • Previous engagement with project Barriers: • Caring responsibilities • Mental health challenges • Low confidence and motivation • Unsure of options Support provided: • One-to-one coaching with a focus on relationship-building • Exploration of needs and interests • Identification of viable career paths • Job search support • CV building • Recognising skills gained through volunteering • Support with personal statement Outcomes attributed to the support: • Application for higher education • Improved confidence and self-belief • Active search for volunteering and work while awaiting outcome of education application	Case study 10 Profile: • Recently left young care provision • University offer, but didn't meet entry requirements • Aspiration to work in cyber security Barriers: • Lack of transport due to theft • Physical impairment • Insufficient Maths and English GCSEs Support provided: • One-to-one mentoring • Identification of long-term goals • Enrolment on an English course • Support to find Maths course • Funding for a new bike to provide transport for courses • Identification of strategies to help with physical impairment Outcomes attributed to the support: • English qualification • Enrolment on Maths course • On track to enter university • Transport barriers overcome
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Other factors influencing outcomes

Other influences, including family support, schools, colleges or other youth services, may have contributed to outcomes for some young people. However, the contribution claim is strengthened by the starting point of the youth-focused cohort and by qualitative evidence that these projects reached young people who were highly disengaged.

The fact that youth-focused projects achieved higher qualification outcomes and lower immediate employment outcomes is consistent with intentional project design rather than weaker performance.

Overall assessment of contribution

Medium-strength evidence suggests that personalised support with youth worker approaches contributed to young people re-engaging with education. The outcome pattern

is clear and consistent with the design of youth-focused projects. The strength of evidence remains medium because there is no external comparison group and because some young people may also have been supported by other services.

This combines quantitative before-and-after survey data and qualitative evidence from local authorities, delivery partners and participants for how the personalised support enabled this.

2.2.6: Contribution claim 6: UKSPF support contributed to participants moving closer to and into employment across all cohorts

This claim brings together the evidence across all participants. It does not repeat the subgroup analysis above. Instead, it assesses whether the overall pattern of outcomes is consistent with the theory that personalised support helped participants reduce their distance from employment.

Across all cohorts, 90% of participants reduced their distance from employment, measured by outcomes like employment, qualifications and increases in soft skills. Participants are counted once, according to their closest-to-employment outcome. This means, for example, that a participant who entered employment and also gained a qualification is counted under employment. It also means that an increase in soft skills is only counted by itself where the participant did not also, for example, gain a qualification. Across the whole sample, average soft skills increased for 40% of participants

This pattern is consistent with the projects' objectives. The projects supported economically inactive people with varied and often complex needs. They did not expect all participants to move directly into employment within the evaluation period. For many participants, progress towards work was expected to involve intermediate outcomes such as improved confidence, skills, qualifications, reduced barriers or active job search:

- 35% moved into employment.⁷
- 53% moved closer to employment. Of these, in order of closest to employment:
 - 8% had a job offer
 - 34% were actively looking for work
 - 44% gained a qualification
 - 11% were in full-time or part-time education
 - 3% improved their average level of soft skills to reduce their expected distance to employment without any additional outcomes above.

⁷ Many of these participants will have also increased their soft skills

- A further 2% reported a reduction in their number of barriers, with no other positive outcomes. And for half of them, barriers reduced even while the average skill levels reported decreased compared to reported levels before the support.
- 10% experienced no apparent reduction in the distance to employment from the above outcomes or a reduction in barriers.⁸

How support contributed to change (delivery model set out in earlier section)

Across all cohorts, the evidence suggests that personalised support reduced distance from employment through two main routes: reducing barriers and improving soft skills (confidence, employability and job search skills).

First, support contributed to reductions in reported barriers:

- Across all participants, the average number of reported barriers fell from 2.0 before support to 1.4 after support.
- The share that reported no barriers increased from 8% to 25%.
- All reported barrier types, including qualifications, job availability, transport, internet access, housing and caring responsibilities, reduced after support.

Addressing barriers was associated with stronger employment outcomes. More than half of participants who reported no remaining barriers after support were in employment, compared with 28% of those who still reported at least 1 barrier. Participants who no longer saw qualifications as a barrier were also more likely than average to be in work or to have gained a qualification.

Second, support contributed to soft skill development:

- Econometric analysis found a statistically significant association between soft skill development and moves into employment, where, on average, a one-point increase in respondents' soft skills was found to be associated with a 6% higher likelihood of moving into employment.
- Qualitative evidence also identified confidence, employability and job search skills as important routes through which support helped participants act on opportunities.
- Among participants who entered employment, 71% saw an increase in at least one soft skill.

Soft skill gains were not always sufficient to secure employment within the evaluation period. Around one in five participants improved their soft skills but did not enter work during the observed period. This is consistent with the theory of change: for some participants, confidence and skills are necessary early steps before employment becomes realistic.

⁸ This includes those who had incomplete skills data along with no other positive outcomes. 1% saw no change in average soft skills.

Qualitative evidence also supported the importance of intermediate outcomes.

Frontline staff explained:

“We have absolutely had lots of successes where participants have gone into the [project] and come out and are now in employment [or] doing qualifications. Lots have just done the six months [in their placement] but learned valuable skills that have moved them on to other employment.” (Frontline staff)

However, the reverse was also true for some participants. While not reflective of the average experience, some participants who started with multiple barriers and low soft skills still moved into employment within the evaluation period. This reinforces the importance of tailored support: starting further from work reduced the likelihood of immediate employment on average but did not prevent substantial progress where support was able to address the right combination of confidence, practical skills and barriers.

The delivery model explains why these routes were possible. Trusted one-to-one relationships enabled advisors to understand individual circumstances, tailor support, sequence activities appropriately and sustain engagement. UKSPF flexibility also allowed projects to respond to practical barriers, including through local delivery, discretionary support and referrals to specialist provision.

Local delivery also mattered. One delivery partner explained:

“The guys [advisors] are out and about in communities. They’re not based in any centres. They’ll meet people sometimes at their homes. They’ll meet people in food banks that are community centres, libraries, etc. It’s about really making the support and the programme as accessible as possible to the participants.” (Delivery partner)

The following two case studies provide illustrative examples, drawn from the experience of real participants, of beneficiaries moving closer to work through personalised support.

Case studies: Beneficiaries moving closer to work through personalised support

Case study 11 Profile: • Aged under 25 • University degree • Recent relationship breakdown Barriers: • Living with parents • Lack of opportunities in degree sector • Neurodiversity • High levels of anxiety Support provided: • One-to-one coaching • Anxiety and crafting workshops • Adjustments for neurodiversity • Text-based communication rather than over the phone • CV refinement • Referred for volunteering • Referral to job search partner Outcomes attributed to the support: • Improved confidence and wellbeing • Full-time employment • Increased experience through volunteering	Case study 12 Profile: • Aged under 25 and classed as NEET (not in education, employment or training) • Living with grandparent • No work experience Barriers: • Learning disability • Low awareness of how to find work • Limited transport options • Alcohol dependence Support provided: • Meetings in public spaces • Identification of skills and interests • CV building and job search support • Arrangement of volunteering • Ongoing in-work support • Support to complete an Access to Work application for transport funding • Referral to alcohol services Outcomes attributed to the support: • Volunteering experience • Short-term paid employment • Increased confidence • Increased wellbeing and resilience
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Other factors influencing outcomes

Other factors, including local labour market conditions, other support and changes in personal circumstances, may have influenced outcomes. The evaluation also did not include a comparison group. These limitations mean that the evidence should not be interpreted as proving that all outcomes were caused solely by UKSPF support.

Progress was also harder for some groups. Participants with persistent health, disability, housing or multiple unresolved barriers were less likely to move quickly into employment, and some continued to report barriers after support. This does not undermine the overall contribution claim, but it shows that personalised employability support cannot fully offset wider structural, health or housing constraints within a short evaluation period.

However, several factors support the contribution claim. Participants often faced complex and connected barriers. Delivery partners and local authorities reported limited availability of comparable support. Available contextual evidence does not suggest that unusually favourable local labour markets explain the scale of observed outcomes. The qualitative evidence also consistently links outcomes to the personalised support model.

Evaluation of European Social Fund (ESF) precursor programmes of support found causal evidence of increases in employment. ESF evaluation is not directly comparable as it counts additional days of employment due to the support and includes participants closer to employment as participants could be unemployed or employed as well as economically inactive. Nevertheless, it shows that broadly similar employability programmes can move people into employment.⁹

Overall assessment of contribution

High-strength evidence suggests that personalised support contributed to reduced reported barriers, improved relevant skills and helped many long-term inactive participants convert readiness into active job search or employment. This combines quantitative before-and-after survey data, self-reported impacts, econometric analysis and qualitative evidence from local authorities, delivery partners and participants for how the personalised support enabled this.

The evidence is strongest at the overall cohort level because it combines consistent survey findings, qualitative evidence and clear associations between reduced barriers, improved skills and employment-related outcomes.

2.2.7: Contribution claim 7: UKSPF support contributed to improvements in wellbeing across all cohorts

This claim considers wellbeing outcomes across participants. It should be interpreted differently from the employment and barrier claims because the survey did not include a dedicated quantitative wellbeing measure. This was a trade-off to balance the burden of questions on respondents and the priorities of the evaluation. At the time of the survey design, wellbeing outcomes were not understood to be priority outcomes and questions on soft skills, barriers, perception of impact of the support and employability outcomes were prioritised. This limits the ability to estimate the scale or persistence of wellbeing change, but the consistency of evidence across participants, delivery partners and local authorities supports the conclusion that wellbeing improvements were an important part of the programme's contribution.

All projects saw improvements in wellbeing across their participants. Qualitative evidence consistently reported improvements in confidence, emotional wellbeing and stability. Reported outcomes included improved self-worth, reduced anxiety, greater independence, better engagement with services, improved family relationships and greater resilience.

For some participants, wellbeing improvement was an outcome in its own right. For others, it was also an enabler of progress towards employment or training.

Participants who experienced mental health challenges, housing instability, financial stress

⁹ [Impact evaluation of the European Social Fund 2014-2020 programme in England - GOV.UK](https://www.gov.uk/government/uploads/system/uploads/attachment_data/file/431111/Impact_evaluation_of_the_European_Social_Fund_2014-2020_programme_in_England_-_GOV.UK.pdf)

or domestic abuse often needed to stabilise their circumstances before they could engage meaningfully with employability support.

This matters for policy because, for participants with complex needs, wellbeing and stability were not separate from employability. They were often preconditions for engaging with training, job search or work.

How support contributed to change

Support contributed to wellbeing through trusted relationships, holistic support and links to wider services. Advisors did not need to deliver all specialist support directly. Their role was often to build trust, understand the participant's circumstances, help them navigate services and advocate for or accompany them where needed.

This was reflected in delivery partner evidence:

“It's not just about getting people into work. It's about the whole story from beginning to end and seeing that confidence building as well.” (Delivery partner)

External services clearly contributed to some wellbeing outcomes, particularly where specialist provision addressed health, housing, debt or domestic abuse-related needs. However, UKSPF support often played the enabling role by helping participants access, coordinate and sustain engagement with those services.

One member of frontline delivery staff explained their role in helping participants access external services:

“We've got them [clients] in touch with social workers, we've got them in touch with their GP, we've got them in touch with the housing benefits organisations and all that kind of stuff. In some clients lives we're the only person who has that ability to connect them to different people. And if we were to go, they'd lose their one point of contact with the rest of the world. A lot of the time they don't have the ability to pick themselves up, so a lot of us have to do the picking up for them. We pick them up, we bring them along to the appointment, we advise them when necessary.”
(Frontline staff)

For participants who faced mental health challenges, housing anxiety, domestic abuse, debt or difficulty engaging with services, consistent advocacy helped stabilise circumstances, reduce anxiety and increase independence. These outcomes then made it more realistic for participants to consider employment, education or training.

The following two case studies provide illustrative examples, drawn from the experience of real participants, of the increased wellbeing of beneficiaries following support received.

Case studies: Wellbeing improvements facilitated by UKSPF support

Case study 13 Profile: • Aged mid-twenties • History of domestic abuse • History of being failed by support services Barriers: • Mental health – anxiety, PTSD, depression • Lack of confidence • Housing issues • Debt Support provided: • Initial phone only contact (at request of beneficiary) • Accompaniment to GP, mental health and pharmacy appointments • Attendance at multi-agency meetings • Liaison with Citizens Advice to develop debt management plan • Referral for practical household support • Co-ordination of support services Outcomes attributed to the support: • Improved confidence and independence • Ability to manage correspondence and attend meetings independently • Reduced anxiety	Case study 14 Profile: • Middle aged • Loneliness and isolation • Recent relationship breakdown Barriers: • Lone parent with no family support • Out of workplace for extended period • Young children Support provided: • One-to-one mentoring • Training courses during school times • Application for in-work childcare support • Application for additional child support • CV writing • Job application support • Interview preparation Outcomes attributed to the support: • Return to part-time employment • Reduction in loneliness • Reduction in feelings of isolation • Improved financial situation
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Other factors influencing outcomes

External services and changes in individual circumstances may have influenced wellbeing outcomes. These should not be treated only as alternative explanations. In many cases, they were part of the mechanism through which UKSPF support contributed to change because advisors helped participants access services they may otherwise not have used effectively.

The lack of a dedicated wellbeing measure means that the evaluation cannot quantify wellbeing change. The evidence is therefore strongest on the existence and nature of wellbeing improvements, rather than their scale or persistence.

Overall assessment of contribution

Medium-strength evidence that the personalisation and holistic approach contributed to improving wellbeing outcomes for participants across all cohorts. The evidence is strong and consistent qualitatively, but the rating remains medium because wellbeing was not directly measured in the survey and because external services also contributed to some outcomes.

2.3: Delivering value for money

Support for economically inactive people is likely to have delivered medium VfM, based on indicative estimates, with high VfM expected under reasonable assumptions.

The impact evaluation shows that projects met their objectives of moving people closer to and into employment within the timeframe of this evaluation. As well as the labour market (wage) benefits, employment is associated with wellbeing impacts. These outcomes are monetised to understand the VfM associated with the projects to date (see [‘UKSPF intervention-level evaluation final technical annex: support for people and skills’](#)).

The observed outcomes suggest a BCR of 1.1 when the employment benefits for only those already in employment are monetised, which is “acceptable” VfM.

The BCR increases to 1.3 (“medium” VfM) when the monetisation also assumes that those who were closer to (but not in) employment within the timeframe of the evaluation actually move into employment within two to five years.

Separately, including the wellbeing benefits associated with employment raises the BCR to 1.8 (also “medium” VfM).

These do not include wider benefits that could not yet be quantified or monetised such as:

- increased tax receipts;
- decreased welfare payments;
- reduced social isolation; and
- increased future employability through soft skill development on its own leading to employment.

These non-monetised benefits are likely to materially impact the VfM assessment. It should also be noted that these benefits are for economically inactive people who are a key target group for government. Often these groups are hard to reach and disengaged.

High VfM requires a BCR of greater than 2. Relatively small changes in assumptions would increase VfM to lie within this range. For instance, an assumption that employment lasts two years on average following support, rather than 1.5 years, increases the BCR from 1.1 to 2.5 (see [‘UKSPF intervention-level evaluation final technical annex: support for people and skills’](#)).

Chapter 3: Process evaluation findings on design and delivery

Beyond the delivery elements already outlined, two further process evaluation themes emerged. All process findings drew on interviews and focus groups with local authority leads, delivery partners, frontline delivery staff and participants, as well as reviews of monitoring data. These were informed by the process map set out in the [Feasibility Report](#).

3.1: It was essential to leverage prior experience of design and implementation

All People & Skills projects in the evaluation had previously existed in some form under ESF provision. While eligibility criteria were typically narrowed to align with UKSPF objectives, project designs largely mirrored earlier ESF-funded activity. Local authorities and delivery partners reported that projects had been refined over several years, with iterative improvements made as learning accumulated. UKSPF funding enabled local authorities to continue interventions viewed as crucial for local economic inclusion and growth.

Prior experience delivering similar projects was considered essential for effective design, smooth implementation and rapid mobilisation. Established frameworks, processes and partnerships, particularly with voluntary, community and social enterprises, helped teams navigate delays and uncertainties. Experience from previous project iterations was also important for smooth delivery. Local authorities and delivery partners relied heavily on prior experience to make delivery as efficient as possible and compress set-up times. Many commented that timelines would have been further constrained if processes needed to be designed from scratch.

Planning and delivery timelines were nevertheless consistently described as constraining. Funding delays further compressed delivery windows, leading to rushed decision-making and challenges with recruiting and retaining staff. Limited time for consultation, testing or commissioning new providers constrained innovation; only minor adjustments to previous models were feasible.

3.2: Monitoring and evaluation was less burdensome but missed key elements

Monitoring requirements were lighter than under ESF, with fewer data points and less detail required. However, the administrative burden on local authorities and delivery partners was increased by unclear guidance in the early stages and initial issues with monitoring tools.

Many local authorities and delivery partners felt that quantitative data alone did not fully capture project impact, particularly progress made by individuals who had not yet moved into employment. They expressed a preference to include qualitative data, such as case

studies, in submissions to MHCLG to reflect individual journeys and outcomes more accurately.

Local authorities and delivery partners found it particularly helpful to measure participant progression by rating participants, or getting participants to rate themselves, on relevant soft skills at the beginning of their engagement and again at the end of their support. Many also measured soft skills at interim points during delivery so that progress could be effectively tracked and additional support could be given to individual participants where necessary.

Chapter 4: Implications and lessons

4.1: Implications for policy makers

The evaluation highlights several considerations for policy makers when interpreting these findings and applying them to future programme design:

- **The evidence consistently points to the role of trusted, one-to-one relationships between participants and advisors** as a central feature associated with positive outcomes for inactive individuals. Delivery models that enabled advisors to exercise judgement, build sustained relationships, tailor support to individual circumstances and signpost to other services appear to underpin the effectiveness of these interventions.
- **Funding flexibility, including the ability of advisors to use budgets to address practical barriers such as transport, was regarded as key to success.** Local partnerships with specialist delivery partners were also a critical component, enabling projects to address a wide range of barriers to employment concurrently.
- **Longer funding periods would allow for continuity of provision and individual members of delivery staff to be consistently employed.** The skills of these staff were seen as key to successful delivery.
- **Supporting inactive individuals with a range of needs in this way can be done in a personalised way and offer VfM.** The evaluation finds that, even under conservative assumptions and within a short observation window, the monetised benefits are expected to exceed programme costs, with additional benefits likely to materialise over time.
- **Schemes would never be expected to move all supported individuals into employment, but this is not required to deliver VfM.** Intermediate outcomes such as reduced barriers and improved soft skills appear to represent meaningful benefits in their own right. For example, projects included individuals who as a result of support received were able to leave the house for the first time in years or were more able to participate actively in society and so could be better neighbours, family members and residents of communities.

4.2: Lessons for evaluators

Future evaluations could benefit from applying the study group approach used for this evaluation. It balances deep learnings from research with individual projects and grouping together to increase available information and the potential for robust findings. The evaluation and reports are designed to make the approach replicable (see detail in the [‘UKSPF intervention-level evaluation final technical annex: support for people and skills’](#)).

Future evaluations could also be improved in the following ways:

- Having multiple follow-ups after the support has finished over a longer period would provide a better indication of longer-term employment impacts, such as whether employment is sustained and if more participants enter employment in a longer period (for instance, after completing further studies). Evaluation timelines meant there was only a short period of around a month before the follow-up.
- Reliable trend data from multiple follow-ups would strengthen future analysis and VfM assessment by making it easier to understand whether, and at what pace, outcomes are sustained, increase or fade after support. It would also generate more data which could make quasi-experimental approaches more feasible, especially where suitable comparison data can also be identified.
- This longer evaluation period could provide an opportunity for matching to similar individuals using HMRC data to provide a comparison group for quasi-experimental analysis. A longer time frame is needed for the employment and salary outcomes to be visible in HMRC data. Challenges would remain on understanding whether these matched groups had any time of employability support.
 - Alternatively, the project designs could be adapted to capture information on local people who could have support but did not. This could be difficult to do in practice and there may be innate differences between those who ask for support and those who do not.
- Capturing wellbeing quantitatively in surveys could provide more specific and robust measures of changes to wellbeing. While trade-offs are needed in surveys to not overburden respondents, this evaluation has shown that further research could strengthen the contribution claim and more could be learned about the follow-on effects from improving wellbeing.

The same survey questions could be used in the future to compare outcomes from similar interventions. This would increase understanding of what is working and under what conditions.